

Paṭicca Samuppāda and How All Other Important Teachings Are Included

Bhante Bodhidhamma · Dharma Talks · 49:49

Namo Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sammāsaṃbuddhassa. Namō Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sammāsaṃbuddhassa. Namō Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sammāsaṃbuddhassa. Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble and fully self-awakened one.

I thought I'd start with a quote from a nun, Mechi Kyao. Has anybody come across her? She's a Thai nun, died in 1991 and was recognized as a fully awakened being, an *arahant*. Her teacher was Ajahn Mahabua, perhaps you know him. This is what she says, and I'm just using this as a beginning and then I thought we'd run through the dependent origination which spurs off into various teachings, and then reread this again and you'll see what a clear statement it is of what it is to live in the world having liberated yourself.

She started off by doing a lot of concentration meditation. And when she went to work with Mahabua, Ajahn Mahabua, she wouldn't take his instructions because he was trying to get her to do *vipassanā*. So he kicked her out. And that sort of woke her up a bit. And having been somewhat humiliated, a little bit of humiliation, she came back and fully realized the path. So she was on a learning curve.

So this is what she says anyway: "Mind, body and essence are all distinct and separate realities. Absolutely everything is known. Earth, water, fire and wind, body, feeling, memory, thought and consciousness. Sound, sight, smells, taste, touches and emotions. Anger, greed, and delusion, all are known. I know them all as they exist in their own natural states. But no matter how much I'm exposed to them, I'm unable to detect even an instant when they have any power over my heart. They arise and cease, they're forever changing. But the presence that knows them never changes for an instant. It stays forever unborn and undying. This is the end of all suffering."

Now, the reason I quoted that, you'll see from the way I talk about dependent origination. So what happened once the Buddha was liberated, there's all sorts of stories as to what teaching came to mind, how he worked it out. The first watch of the night, he went through dependent origination one way, and the second watch he came the other way, and on the third watch, he went both ways and then he did that with the Four Noble Truths and so on and so forth.

The interesting thing is that once he had had this cataclysmic insight into human nature, it wasn't as though he knew everything. It had to be explained. He had to go through to try and make sense of what he'd actually seen. And the experience of *nibbāna*, if you want to look at it from the point of view of self, the collapse of self, which is the underlying delusion, of course, begs the question, well, how did I get

there? And that's where this dependent origination comes in.

So dependent origination means, of course, that everything is dependent on something else for it to arise. Nothing arises of its own accord. Sometimes called the wheel, but that's taken from the Tibetan tradition because they made a nice little picture out of it.

Now, and in the early scriptures, when he's talking, you can see that the discourse, the teaching is not formulated. Often he just talks about the six links. Sometimes it's down to even three. And later on, as he's having to go around and teach, and remember in those days, there's no mobile phones, you can't record anything. So he's going to have to say the same thing every time somebody asks him. Everywhere he went, they'd ask him the same question, how do you get liberated? Here we go again with James.

So as time goes on, he formulates and he comes up with these enormous lists. There actually are about 300 and odd lists, but we're only concerned with the main ones in this particular teaching of dependent origination. You want to know all the lists, there's a whole collection of them of course in what's called the Numerical Sayings and they're all put together according to ones like one of these that's *nibbāna*, two of these, three of these, and it just goes all the way up to eleven. That's there if you want to it, it's a big thick book.

So it starts, the beginning of the dependent origination is this word *avijjā*, which is often translated as ignorance. But that gives it a feeling that you should have known, you shouldn't have been such an idiot. You should have known what was going to happen. But actually the word *avijjā* is very simply not knowing, just don't know. And it's from this don't know that we land in a situation and presume it's quite understandable that this is what we are.

So there we are, we're born and there's that slow awakening through our babyhood and into childhood. And what do you experience? You only experience this body, this mind, this relationship with the world. So it's quite understandable that you come to the age, a certain age and you say, well, this is me. This is me, you see.

Now, because of that, we, of course, have a wrong relationship immediately with the world. So what is that relationship? Well, I just want to make myself happy. That's pretty straightforward. I just want to be happy. And I find that if I collect a lot of things, I get more and more happy. I've got lots of money, lots of friends, a good job, two cars and all that sort of stuff. I feel much more happy. Yeah, that sort of accumulation. And sometimes I might be happy reading and listening to music and art and nature and all that sort of stuff. But all of it is geared upon making me happy because that's all I want to be. I just want to be happy for heaven's sake.

Now, of course, once you've accumulated, there's the danger that you might lose it. Hence, protectiveness. Who are you protecting against? Well, everybody else. So you have to create this idea of pushing things away. And there's your aversion. And if, of course, what you are dealing with is bigger than you, bigger

than me, well, you've got to run for it. So there you have your basic tripod, you might say, of how we fundamentally react to the world because we've mistaken it to be ourselves. So acquisitiveness, aversion and fear.

And from there on, of course, we do things. Sometimes, of course, we do things for other reasons, like out of love, compassion, joy. But even that slightly tainted, you know, you can know that when you do somebody a good turn and they don't say thank you. Well, that really hurts, doesn't it? I mean, you need to be appreciated. So there's always that little bit of conceit in there somewhere, right? And so, these three things lead us into actions. They're actions through thought, we create stories, etc., through what we say, and of course, what we do. And then, because they come in from an unwholesome base, we have that secondary layer of misery, guilt, shame, remorse, and so on.

So you can see we've entered into a relationship with the world which is causing us to have developed habits that are unwholesome. And that's what happens in the dependent origination. Out of this ignorance, we create the delusion, the delusion of me being this human being, a self. And because of that, I have these habits. They're known as, in the Pali, it's translated as volitional conditionings, right? Basically, they're just your habits.

Now, those run underneath everything we're doing. From the moment you wake up to the moment you fall asleep, they're running there as potential, okay? This potential of delusion and the potential of unwholesome habits. And they run over everything, okay?

Now, because of that, so *avijjā paccayā saṅkhārā*, *saṅkhārā paccayā viññāṇa*, it's because of these arising of these habits provoked, shall we say, by stimulus from the outside, by other people, even by from the habits themselves inside, like you wake up in the morning and you feel really excited about something. So that initial arising, shall we say, has to manifest. And what it manifests on is this screen, just like this screen that I'm looking at now with you all sitting there. It's a screen which is sensitive to information that comes upon it. And it's always coming from the sense bases, one of which is the mind itself. So there you have your beginning of every moment. You have that consciousness which is receiving information, right?

So this is not the same as awareness, okay? It's not the same as awareness. This is consciousness. This is what you're aware of, okay?

Now, out of that consciousness, you become aware of, and this is the first deconstruction of the Buddha, the body and mind. And to make that very clear to ourselves, for those of you who know, that's actually the first insights. Those are the first insights, to know that we are a compound of physicality and mentality, and that the one is always reacting off the other.

And in our meditation, that's why I keep stressing in the morning, you see, to make that very clear to ourselves, even during the day, to make that very clear to ourselves, that if I'm going to open a door and I'm standing there, there's an intention, that's mentality, intention, intention. And then I empower the

intention and the hand moves. So the hand is, of course, physicality. When I touch the door handle, what I'm getting are sensations from the physical nature. But it's the mind that actually experiences it as either cold or warm and so on and so forth. All you're getting from your fingertips or your hand are just physical sensations. And it's beginning to undo these things, undo that process, which is slowly deconstructing this idea that I am an integer, that I am a one, that I am whole, entire.

Now, because of this body and mind, *nāma rūpa paccayā saḷāyatana*. So the *saḷāyatana* are your six senses dependent on the body and mind. Now this is important because a consciousness is dependent on one of these six senses, right? You can't have a consciousness that mixes them both. Now it feels that way, you know, like you're at home and you're watching TV and you're having a coffee and biscuit or something, and it seems all one. You're watching, you're hearing, you're tasting, and it's all heavenly. But actually in Buddhist psychology these are all very separate consciousnesses just running one after the other. A bit like the old film really where you get 26 frames per second or something. And that gives you the illusion of continuity.

So those are your six sense bases, and the sixth, of course, is the mind. Actually, it's all mind because, of course, the contact, which is the next point, see? Because of these six senses, we have contact. The contact is the point where the sense base touches upon the object. So the physical base is, you know, the base of touch is straightforward, I mean if my hands touch each other that point of contact is my primary percept. Now that's still coming into the mind, you see, still coming into the mind. At the ear for instance, the primary percept that comes in, the primary information that comes in is just pressure, it's just pressure right, you can actually experience that, and it's only when it's taken into the mind that it creates an actual sound, right? So it's the same with seeing.

Oh dear, there's a book by this American teacher, I can't remember her name now, it'll come to me all of a sudden. And I think it's called *Insight*, something like that. And she's a Mahāsi practitioner. Actually, she died quite young from brain cancer, for heaven's sake. But her insight was how what she was seeing that just broke up into millions of pixels. And when you think about it, that's exactly what's there on the retina. All you've got are these little endings of nerves which are sensitive to light. And from that she saw how that information is taken into the mind and created into an image.

So that's the point of contact. It's very, very basic. And that's what I'm really trying to drive you towards when I say at breakfast, drive your attention into your tongue, right? To get right down to tasting before you give it a name, before you have any idea of what it is that you're actually tasting. Okay? And that's the point of contact.

Now, at the next level, when it's finally produced a feeling of some sort, a sensation of some sort, then you have that judgmental, judicious, should we say, judicious moment where you realize that something is either painful or pleasurable. So everything that we experience has to be on that line. It's either very, very pleasurable, moving towards neutral, or very, very painful. That's it. Everything we experience, you'll be

able to put somewhere on that line. And that's the duality that we live in.

You can't overcome that. Whatever we perceive, whatever we feel, whatever we experience as pleasant will remain so. You can't get rid of that experience. You can't wash it out. And the same, of course, is true with something that's unpleasant. Feeling, emotions, unpleasant thinking, unpleasant thoughts that come to the mind, etc. So that's the point of *vedanā*, feeling.

And it's at this point that this underlying business begins to manifest. So remember, so underlying, we've got this ignorance, this not knowing, this delusion, and all these little habits that we have. And so in comes this contact. So we're walking down the street and we see something. Well, not these days. We don't go shopping anymore. You're on the screen and it comes up with this thing that you're looking for, a new whatever. A new mobile and it shoots up on the screen you see and immediately you get this, you get this little movement from a habit which is not only to do with all the stuff that you know about mobile, it's also to do with oh I'd like that right. So there's your, there's your *taṇhā*, there's your desire.

And now this desire remember is coming out of that fundamental delusion of seeking happiness in the sensual world. And what happens is, of course, that happiness that we have becomes dependent on what it is that we own. There's your problem. So you take away what it is that you own and misery arises, a sense of loss. It can be very little, of course, but it can also be quite great. And when you extend this to relationship with people, it can be awfully full of grief.

So that business of *taṇhā* is a way of relating to something whereby whatever mental state we are enjoying or not enjoying, aversion, fear, all those sorts of things, is dependent on something, depending on something over which I don't actually have control. So it's not a brilliant situation to get ourselves into, but that's basically about 90% of our lives.

So I was saying this morning that there was, there's only a few of us here, that you know there's this danger with climate change that there won't be any more tea. Well you can imagine, I mean that's absolute disaster, you know, it takes away the will to live. So that sort of dependency on tea, coffee, drinks, biscuits and all that, they're only very minor. But when you don't get it, you realize how much of your present happiness, the bit that was feeling bored and using it to escape from boredom or escape from a bit of depression, how you've lifted yourself out by attaching to something which is going to create a pleasant mental state. Okay? So this is *taṇhā*. That's this.

And of course, the Buddha points to this as the crucial point. And it's the point of escape. That's the point of escape from this delusion. It's to catch those desires and allow them to burn out. And that eventually undermines the habit and it doesn't, see, this is the interesting thing that we'll come back to Mechi Kyao. It doesn't actually destroy them, but it destroys their power over us. I'll come back to that in a minute.

So once we understand that we've got to be absolutely aware, we've got to be attentive to the arising of desires. And it's very difficult unless we're in a very calm state, unless we're actually not rushing, we're

not caught up in something. And so if we can keep bringing ourselves back to a sort of stillness every so often throughout the day, you become much more aware of these little, these little pushes. And it's not to get all guilty and awful if you actually give in and find yourself eating a whole packet of biscuits. It's just a case of recognizing that's what you've done. So you make the decision that next time this comes up, I have to have some sort of strategy.

For instance, I won't buy any more biscuits.

If we can become aware of the strength of these desires and how to allow them to exhaust themselves, we've actually found a way out of suffering. I'm using suffering in that big sense of everything that's uncomfortable, slightest discomfort to something which is quite horrible.

Now the next point is also the point where the fundamental delusion comes in, and that's the point of identity. The first thing that we're aware of is like. So, you know, you're walking down, like the other day, we were walking down on the Shropshire Hills down here, and we went into Church Stretton, and the chippy was open. Well, I hadn't had chips for so long, you see. And so when we smelled these chips, there was no way we could drag ourselves out of the shop.

So now, if you see, first of all, there comes the smell of chips. And then with it, of course, there comes this memory of the delight with tomato sauce and brown sauce and for some people, mayonnaise. I can't understand it, frankly. But there we are. So we stopped. And before we know it, we're in there buying chips.

Now, what's happened there? The information came in, there was a translation of it into something that I could recognise – chips – and with it there arose this feeling, this lovely feeling that I've engendered in the past over chips. And with it, of course, there comes this desire: more, right?

Now, nothing's going to happen unless I identify with it. "I want the chips" – that "I" has to come in. If that doesn't come in, I'm just left with an unrequited desire. I'm just left there with the feeling of wanting, and nothing's going to happen. The first thing is I've got to say, "I want the chips," right? That "I" has to come in. And as soon as I say "I," the next point happens automatically. It's very difficult to stop it once you've said, "I want those chips." You're in there.

The next point is the empowerment, which is the will. So another point of escape from suffering is that point of "I." It's extremely difficult to catch. You've got to be really on your toes to catch that. The next part is almost unstoppable because you've given your assent, right? Just like the Queen, you've given your assent and that's the end of it.

Now the word for that is *upādāna*. Sometimes they translate it as grasping, but it's the point where you identify with the desire. Remember, this is all negative. We're not here looking at the positive side, driven by love, compassion, sympathetic joy, etc. But as I say, even there, there will be some little smidgen of conceit: "How wonderful I am." All that sort of stuff.

So after this identity, there comes the empowerment. Now the empowerment is, in the dependent origination, called *bhava*. *Bhava* means becoming. So the self is now recreating itself. The self is that idea of "this being me, this is my pleasure, this is my chip, these are my chips," etc. There's a whole area of possession and identity around it.

There was once, I was in India, and somebody bought me a bag of nuts on the streets. It was out on the edge of town, if I remember rightly. I can't remember – yeah, the bus station or something. And I had this bag of chips. And I swear there was this bang on my head. And when I looked, it had gone. It was absolutely magic. And it was a monkey. It had jumped on my head and stolen my peanuts. Well, I mean, you can imagine how I felt. And the bus was off. So I lost out on these peanuts, for heaven's sake.

So that point of identity, and then there's the *bhava*, which is the empowerment. So there's the will there. There's a recreation of the self as you go through the action of eating chips, right? The self is constantly being recreated as that process recreates itself. And of course, there's *kamma*, there's an action. So there's will, there's action, and there's the self involved at that crucial moment.

And from then on, of course, the action is completed, right? You begin the action. As soon as the will is empowered, you go through the action and you complete the action. And that's it. And now if it's done from an unwholesome point of view, it's fed back down to these two underlying connections. The ignorance, the not knowing, has now been reinforced: "This is me," right? And the habit of, well, in this case, eating chips – of seeking happiness in chips. So that's the whole wheel there completed.

We've got little branches that come off that, which tell us something about the way the Buddha cross-sections a human being. So here we see the Buddha, here we see the person in action. But when we look at the dependent origination again, you can see that there are points where the teaching expands what it is that he's explaining.

So at contact, for instance, the first deconstruction is the body and mind. Next one is that contact, and that contact where we're actually down in the body, down at that physicality. We can discern that the sensations coming in are usually of four types: the sense of pressure, the earth element; the sense of fluidity, of cohesiveness – that's the element of water; the movement that's there; and of course the temperature, the fire element, warmth or cool.

So when you're down right there at the feeling base – through your hands, your feet, your body, etc. – that is a combination of those that is creating your initial information. And the mind does the rest. The mind takes it in at the sense door of the mind where it's connecting and creates what we experience.

When it comes to other things like the ear, it's actually just pressure. That's all you're getting from the ear, just pressure from airwaves. The eye is normally expressed as heat, some form of heat or warmth. The basic animal senses of smelling and tasting are, of course, a bit more difficult to explain in that way. But there will be this basic contact. So that's the point of contact.

When it comes to feeling, that again is split into pleasant feeling, unpleasant feelings, neutral feelings. But they're also physical – they're physical neutral feelings, like now for instance, if you put your attention on your knees, you probably don't feel very much, very neutral – and emotional feelings, mental feelings, both what is pleasant, unpleasant, and then just that place in the middle where there isn't that much emotional stuff going on. So that's your next point of experience, the next point of investigation: feeling.

And then the next one is, of course, this business of desire, this *taṇhā*. It's a special type of desire, remember. It's a desire based on that delusion of seeking happiness in the sensual world. And that desire expresses – it's a wrong word really, *taṇhā*. It's very difficult to translate. It includes wanting, not wanting. So the wanting is what we would call desire. The not wanting is aversion and fear. That's what it is. And these aversion and fear are our suppressive measures. That's how we keep things out of consciousness. And we then place the attention on something which is delightful so that what we often take pleasure in is actually also an escape from what we don't want to feel.

That's why pleasure has such a hold on us. That's why we get glued onto videos and stuff like that – anything but to actually go into ourselves and feel these very unpleasant mental states. But of course that is very much part of our practice. I would say it's about 99.9% of our practice is the process of purifying the heart.

So that's also important to remember that in your practice, you're not trying to be happy, right? That's a big mistake. You're not trying to make your life more comfortable. You're not trying to escape suffering. You're actually trying to sit in the bonfire. And this is the bonfire that we've created for ourselves.

So that's at the point of feeling. And when we're there with these different types of feelings, whether they're pleasant and we can see ourselves drawn to them, see there's that desire drawn to them, try to develop them. And how do they develop? They develop through the mind. They develop through our imagination in the sitting. In ordinary daily life, we'll actually do something that creates that happiness. But when we're sitting still, this energy's got nowhere to go, so it begins to create stuff in the mind. Whether it creates stuff in the mind or in ordinary daily life, remember, if it's unwholesome, it's developing it.

So the only way that these unwholesome states can be exhausted is through direct feeling of them and allowing them to manifest in consciousness. We know from our own psychotherapy that if you suppress stuff, it's working there in the background somewhere. So when you're sitting and perhaps some sadness comes up or some anger or whatever, you have to deal with that. And you have to be very careful not to let the mind wander on it, because as soon as it wanders, it's developing it. If you want to make yourself more depressed, just keep having depressing thoughts. Just keep telling yourself how depressed you are. And then, "I'm depressed, may everybody else be depressed." So it becomes a wish that everybody else is in the same boat.

So a lot of our practice is to be able to sit still with that. And as you know from last night's talk with Wei,

the Buddha splits those into five different categories. So the skill, one of our major skills to learn in meditation, is how not to be carried away and how to keep coming back to the body. And I think if we can really drive home to ourselves that every time we indulge anything unwholesome we're actually making it worse, then I think that will help us to come off it more quickly.

So that's that abyss of *taṇhā*. The *upādāna*, which is the sense of self, now begins to manifest as conceit. And that's always comparison. I'm better than somebody or I'm worse than somebody. When I'm better than somebody, I feel great. When I'm worse than somebody, I don't feel so good at all. And the other one is "I'm equal to." And you might think, oh well, that's all right, that's humble – "I'm equal to." But actually, when you look at whom you're equal to, they happen to be either superior or inferior to another group. It's just a transferred sense of conceit.

And conceit is the last thing to go, right? It's the last thing to go. As we work back into ourselves, as we begin to purify the heart, undo a lot of the unwholesome habits, undo a lot of the misconceptions that we have, the last thing to go is that sense of self and with it the conceit. It's the last little bit that hooks us into this life, into the wrong life, into the life of *saṃsāra* – this constantly trying to find happiness in the world and constantly failing to be fully satisfied one way or the other.

So that's the point of the self coming in, right? Now, what do we mean by this self? Self is the sense of my being there. So for instance, one moment that we can really experience a physical self is when you hurt yourself badly, right? So when somebody stands on your toe on the bus or the tube or train or something like that, or you catch your finger in the door – or you bite your tongue, that's a brilliant one – in that singular moment you are your toe, you are your finger, you are your tongue. And then you bounce out of it and become the observer, become the knower of this pain. And that's when the anger comes up. You start beating the door up or the person who just stood on your toe. And that's – you've now jumped out of being the body, the physical body, into being an emotion, right?

And then later on, you think about it. You're sitting in a chair and you're off mumbling about it, about this person who dared to stand on your toe, and it goes on and on. And so you become the whole thinking process which, of course, is being excited from this emotional base. So that's what we mean by a self, right? As an absorption.

And so we can be a physical self, we can be an emotional self, we can be an imaginative, intellectual self. Now, when we're in that state of the observer, we've pulled out of those identities. We've become the observer, which is separate from what we are experiencing. The observer, the knower, the feeler, the experiencer. That's a different sense of self, and it's not engaged. It's standing apart from. But it's still a sense of self. The awareness still is sensing itself as a self, right? And that's, of course, a mirror image, right? It's aware of itself. Where is it aware of itself? It's aware of itself on that screen of consciousness.

So when we're watching these things and unwittingly, whether we know it or not, we're actually running through the middle part of that dependent origination. We're actually unwittingly teaching ourselves that

there's a place we can be which is untouchable. Everything's an object. It can't touch me.

And then when it comes – so that's this sense of self, and of course that sense of self as the awareness, as the knower, as the feeler, is of course the last thing that has to drop away. And you can't make that drop away, you can't tell it to go away. The more you try and get rid of it, the more you create a self that's trying to get rid of it. So it's an ever-ending circle.

But you might find in a very quiet moment when the body's very still, the heart's very calm, and you are very clearly this observer, the feeler, the knower inside you, you might just have enough space, enough stillness to glance back into that awareness. It's as though the awareness is becoming aware of itself. It's as though you're looking into the mirror and you're catching something about the awareness. And the question is, what's in there? What's it made of?

Just that little glance will help you to perceive that there's nothing there. So the awareness itself is empty. Empty of what? Empty of everything it experiences. That's what the word emptiness is referring to. When the Buddha said it's *śūnya*, it's empty of everything that the psychophysical organism produces. And it has a sense base. The sense base is that field, that screen of consciousness.

And this is mirrored in the senses. The senses themselves don't have the object of themselves. So, for instance, if your tongue had an innate taste of curry, it would be very difficult to experience the wonder of vanilla ice cream. It's because the tongue is empty of taste that it can taste all the other tastes. It's the same with the eye. Because there's no light in the eye and the retina, it can experience light. And the same with hearing, etc. Unless, like me, you've got tinnitus. Then you've got interference. That's called an interference, coming from who knows where.

So that point of seeing things and then the point of *bhava*, the point of becoming. In our meditation, we want to stay very close to what's actually being offered so that we don't fall into the habit of identifying and thereby creating something new out of what we're experiencing, whether it's pleasure or not pleasure.

Because the process of *vipassanā* is the discovery of something in us which does not belong to that whole process.

Now, if I go back to this wonderful... And, you know, I have to say this, and it's probably something that they would call heretical, but this for me is a clearer statement than all the statements the Buddha made. So she says, "Body, mind, and essence are all distinct and separate realities." So here we're beginning - the body is, physicality is one thing, mentality is another. And then she talks about this essence. I remember this is a translation from Thai, but I'm pretty sure it's fairly close. Essence, right? So she used the word essence. So something that has its own existence and essence.

Separate realities - they're separate realities, right? One is mundane, conventional, and one is supramundane. "Absolutely everything is known." So here's your four basic qualities - earth, water, fire,

and wind, right? *Mahābhūta*, four great elements. Then you've got your five *khandhas*, your five heaps: the body, physical feelings - feeling, all your... sorry, sensations, feeling, memory. Now, they've translated it as memory, but in a sense, that's right. It's all your concepts, right? Your concepts hold your experience. Concepts, percepts, concepts, but it basically is your memory, intellectual memory. Now it also translates *s añkhāra* as thought, but it ought to be habits, okay? And consciousness.

And then the six sense bases - sounds, sights, smells, tastes, touches, and it's got here emotions, but it's actually everything that the mind actually experiences, both the imagination, the thought patterns, and the emotions.

Now here's the thing - she also sees traces of anger, greed, and delusion. In other words, those three things, right? The sense of self being the edge of creation, you might say, of thinking that here we will find real happiness. And those little movements, those little traces still in the mind of wanting, not wanting... There's an actual word for them, *vāsanā* - they're leftover traces.

So for instance, there was a case in the scriptures of somebody who was a Brahmin and he became fully liberated. And he's talking to the other monks as if they were of a lower caste. And they complained because in the order you're not supposed to do that. Everybody has equal status. And the Buddha said - and they asked him, "How could he do this and be fully liberated?" He said, "Well, it's just a trace. It's just an old habit which just has trace. But he means no harm." That's the point.

"All are known, I know them all as they exist" - in other words, as they arise - "in their own natural states, just as they are. I'm not playing around with them anymore. They're just arising and passing away. But no matter how much I'm exposed to them, I'm unable to detect even an instant when they have any power over my heart." So this is, of course, heart meaning the basic quality of awareness, affectionate awareness. "They arise and cease, they're forever changing. But the presence" - see, that's another word for awareness - "the presence that knows them never changes for an instant. It is forever unborn and undying. This is the end of suffering."

So you can see that the way she's explaining how she experiences life includes virtually all the Buddha's teachings there. I think it's fantastic. It's on the window ledge as you come in to the meditation room.

So just to conclude, our understanding is to actually see where the escape is. The escape lies at the psychological level when desire arises. That's the only point of choice that we have. Now I say choice - it's not a free choice, because if you make the wrong choice, you move into a hell realm, and if you make the right choice, you move into a heavenly realm. So it's not much of a choice really.

So when a desire comes up, and you can see it as being unwholesome, we've got to let it go. And if a desire comes up that we see is wholesome, then if it's the right thing to do, we empower it. So that's the point where you have choice. After that, you're committed and you've created an action. You've developed a habit and that's the end of that. And there are consequences, of course. That's what we mean by *kamma*.

The deeper level is to see impermanence, that everything is changing. So this begins to undermine the sense of self. Undermine the sense of solidity. Undermine the sense of continuity. To see everything as arising and passing away. And then underneath that, of course, is this sense of self. And that's quite difficult to get to. It comes when the awareness, even if only for a moment, can stand outside the five *khandhas* and get that objective view, get that objective grasp of things. And that begins to undermine the sense of self.

When we have a deep enough experience of either of these three characteristics of existence, that, in a sense, changes our relationship to the world. And that's what we call somebody who's a stream entrant. That's somebody who now can't go back, can't go back into a full delusive state.

And finally, just to express what that means - at the age of seven, most of us have this awakening, right? There's an awakening to morality. We begin to understand what's right and what's wrong. This is the Garden of Eden and that apple, and the magical world disappears. You know, Father Christmas simply can't come down the chimney anymore. Now, once you've made that leap, that's it. You can't go back. You can't be a three-year-old again. Not unless you die and start again, as it were.

So that's the same with these insights. The more insights we have - as an accumulation, it can be an accumulation of insights - there comes a point where you can't fall backwards. It's got a stamp on it.

So there we are. I can only hope my words have been of some assistance, that they have not caused even greater confusion, and that you will, by your continuous unstinting effort, liberate yourselves from all suffering, sooner rather than later.

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